force.’[22] This request was an allusion to a growing crisis with the baggage animals, which had just got much more serious after half of the Shah’s camels had died from eating a poisonous Sindhi plant, a cousin of the foxglove, so leaving the Shah and his troops, like those still broiling in the humidity of the Indus Delta, ‘in the lurch without the means of moving’.

Relations between Shuja and Macnaghten did not get off to a much better start. ‘The Shah, I am sorry to say, talks foolishly every time I see him on the subject of how confined his territories are to be,’ wrote the Envoy, ‘and frequently says it would have been much better for him to have remained in Ludhiana. The next time he touches on the subject, I intend to remind him of the verse of Sa’adi, “If a King conquers seven regions he would still be hankering after another territory.”’ He then added, ominously for the future, ‘I hardly think the 50,000 rupees per mensem will suffice for the Shah’s expenses.’[23]

There were also, as ever, tensions between Macnaghten and Burnes, exacerbated by the fact that Macnaghten had been given the job Burnes wanted, while Burnes had been awarded the knighthood the profoundly snobbish Macnaghten would have loved. As a result Macnaghten routinely patronised Burnes, whom he tended to treat as an over-promoted teenager, while Burnes regarded Macnaghten as ‘a man of no experience and quite unskilled with natives. He is also very hasty in taking up and throwing off plans.’[24]

It was therefore a disgruntled and disunited army that finally began to converge in one place at Shikarpur at the end of February 1839, a full three months after the scheduled start of the invasion. The only people impressed by the Army of the Indus were the Afghans who, unaware of the lack of co-ordination, discipline and foreplanning, or the squabbles between the commanders, heard only exaggerated stories about the size of the enormous force heading towards them. Dost Mohammad’s Barakzai half-brothers in Kandahar felt particularly vulnerable: as in 1834, they would be the first target of any advance into Afghanistan through the Bolan, and now that Vitkevitch had been withdrawn and his promises of Russian military support disowned, they knew all too well how ill prepared they were to meet a modern, well-drilled and well-equipped colonial army. Years later, the epic poets of the country recalled the rumours that spread of the huge British invasion force marching towards their mountains and valleys: